

IGNITION AGENCY

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VERSION 2.0



10 Automations Every SME Should Have Running

ZAPIER

MAKE

N8N

SHOPIFY

A Practical Starter Kit for Time-Poor Business Owners

Who Are Sick of Doing Manually What Software Should Do.

What's Inside

Introduction	The 10 Hours a Week You're Wasting
Part 2	The Automation Mindset
Part 3	Tool Overview — Zapier vs Make vs n8n (+ AI Agents)
Recipe #1	Lead Capture → CRM Entry
Recipe #2	New Order → Fulfilment Notification
Recipe #3	Weekly Report → Email Delivery
Recipe #4	Customer Review Request
Recipe #5	Invoice → Payment Reminder Sequence
Recipe #6	Social Mention → Team Alert
Recipe #7	New Inquiry → Instant Response + Booking Link
Recipe #8	Inventory Low → Supplier Email Alert
Recipe #9	Monthly P&L; → Accountant Delivery
Recipe #10	Competitor Price Change → Your Alert
Part 5	Build Your First Automation (Step-by-Step)
Part 6	Automation Stack by Budget (\$0 / \$100 / \$500)
Part 7	What NOT to Automate
Part 8	Maintenance — Keeping Your Automations Healthy
Bonus	Automation Audit Worksheet
Next Steps	Free Audit Offer

The 10 Hours a Week You're Wasting

(And How to Get Them Back)

Let's be honest. If you run a small or medium business, there's a solid chance you're doing at least a dozen things every week that a piece of software could handle in zero seconds flat. Not because you're disorganised — but because nobody ever sat you down and showed you the alternative.

The average SME owner wastes 8–12 hours per week on fully automatable tasks. That's one working day. Every single week. Gone.

Sound familiar?

- You get a website lead. You open your CRM, create a contact, copy name/email/phone. Five minutes. Every. Single. Lead.
- A Shopify order comes in. You forward it to your warehouse via email or WhatsApp. Two minutes. Per order.
- Friday afternoon: your manager needs the weekly sales report. You open four tabs, pull numbers, paste into a spreadsheet, format it, email it. Forty-five minutes.
- A customer buys something. You'll ask for a review. When you remember. Sometimes.

What's Actually Possible

The 10 automations in this kit collectively save the average SME owner 6–12 hours per week. At \$150/hour, that's \$900–\$1,800 in recovered time. Every week. But even if you don't bill by the hour, reclaiming that time means:

- More time on strategic work that actually grows your business
- Less context-switching and mental load
- Fewer things falling through the cracks
- Faster response times to customers (which drives revenue)
- The ability to actually switch off on weekends

The Automation Reality Check

Automation IS: Connecting software so it talks automatically. Triggering actions (emails, entries, alerts) based on events. Removing humans from repetitive, rule-based tasks.

Automation IS NOT: Replacing the relationships and judgment that make your business valuable. Complicated or expensive — most of this is free or near-free. Only for tech companies (it's arguably more valuable for traditional businesses).

You don't need to know how to code. You don't need a developer. You need this kit, a free account on one automation platform, and about an hour of your time. That's it.

The Automation Mindset

What to Automate First and Why

Not all automation is created equal. Before you start plugging things together, spend five minutes thinking about what to automate and in what order. Get this right and you'll save yourself the frustration of automating something that doesn't move the needle.

The Four Pillars of a Good Automation Target

A task is worth automating when it ticks at least three of these:

- 1

It happens frequently
 - Do it daily → automate it. Do it twice a year → manual is fine.
- 2

It follows a consistent pattern
 - "Every time X happens, do Y" is the sweet spot. Complex judgment every time → not yet ready.
- 3

It's currently causing problems
 - Dropped leads. Late invoices. Missed follow-ups. If the manual version is failing you, automation is the fix.
- 4

The stakes of a mistake are high
 - If forgetting a follow-up costs you a \$5K sale, that task is worth protecting with automation.

The Three Automation Layers

LAYER	TYPE	DESCRIPTION	BUILD ORDER
Layer 1	Capture	Ensure nothing falls through the cracks. Lead forms, inquiry responses, order confirmations.	First
Layer 2	Communication	Ensure customers and team hear from you at the right moment. Review requests, payment reminders, booking confirmations.	Second
Layer 3	Intelligence	Aggregate and surface information you'd otherwise dig for. Weekly reports, P&L; summaries, competitor monitoring.	Third

Quick ROI Check — Run This Before Any Automation

Time Cost = Minutes per occurrence × Frequency per week × 52 × Hourly rate ÷ 60

Example: 5 min entering leads × 20 leads/week × 52 × \$100/hr ÷ 60 = \$8,667/year

Add Error Cost: 2 dropped leads/month × \$500 value × 12 = \$12,000/year

Total cost of doing it manually: \$20,667/year vs \$0–\$600/year to automate.

The decision makes itself.

Tool Overview

Zapier vs Make vs n8n — Plus AI Agents

Three platforms power most SME automation in 2026. Each has strengths. The right choice depends on your technical comfort, budget, and how complex your automations are likely to get. Here's the straight version.

FEATURE	ZAPIER	MAKE	N8N
Pricing (2026)	Free (100 tasks/mo) or \$29.99+/mo	Free (1,000 ops/mo) or \$16+/mo	Free (self-hosted) or \$24+/mo cloud
Ease of use	Very easy — built for beginners	Moderate — more visual power	Moderate — technical but flexible
App integrations	7,000+	2,000+	500+ (growing fast)
AI agent support	Zapier AI Actions + Copilot	AI modules + Claude/GPT nodes	Native AI agent workflows (best-in-class)
Custom code	Yes (paid plans)	Yes (paid plans)	Yes — JavaScript + Python nodes
Self-hosting	No	No	Yes (cheapest long-term)
Best for	Beginners, simple 2-step flows	Intermediate; data-heavy flows	Tech-savvy; complex or AI-powered flows

Zapier — Best for Beginners

Largest app library (7,000+), friendliest interface, best beginner documentation. In 2026, Zapier's AI Copilot can actually build Zaps for you by describing what you want in plain English. **Use if:** you're new to automation and want wins fast without fighting the tooling. **Watch out for:** costs scale quickly. For 10 automations at real volume, budget \$29–\$49/month.

Make — The Sweet Spot

Sits between Zapier and n8n. Visual workflow builder with far more powerful data handling and branching logic — and significantly cheaper than Zapier. **Use if:** you want more power than Zapier without the complexity of n8n. **Watch out for:** the "operations" pricing model can be confusing; "operations" ≠ "tasks" in Zapier terms. Budget \$29–\$49/month for all 10 recipes.

n8n — The Power User's Choice

Open-source, self-hostable, and in 2026 the leading platform for AI agent workflows. Native integrations with OpenAI, Claude (Anthropic), and Gemini that are genuinely excellent. If you want to build automations where an AI makes decisions — not just passes data — n8n is where you'll end up. Self-hosted on a cheap \$6/month VPS: effectively free forever. **Use if:** you're technical, want AI capabilities, or want to stop paying per-task. **Watch out for:** setup takes longer. But the payoff is real.

A Note on AI Agents in 2026

AI agents are now mainstream — not a bonus feature. All three platforms support automation flows where AI (Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini) reads data, makes decisions, and takes actions.

In each recipe below we flag the AI Enhancement — the upgrade that turns a basic automation into something genuinely intelligent. Start without them. Add them when you're ready. They change the game.

Recipe #1: Lead Capture → CRM Entry

Never Lose a Lead Again

TIME SAVED	DIFFICULTY	CATEGORY	ANNUAL VALUE
3–7 min per lead	Beginner	Capture (Layer 1)	\$5K–\$20K+/year

What It Does

Every time someone fills out a form on your website — contact form, quote request, enquiry — their details automatically appear in your CRM as a new contact. No copying. No pasting. No forgetting. The automation also tags the lead with the source, sets a follow-up task, sends an instant acknowledgement email to the prospect, and notifies you or your team via Slack or email.

This is the single most impactful automation for most SMEs. Losing even one lead because of manual process failure is unacceptable.

What You Need

TOOL	PURPOSE	COST
Website form	Capture lead info	Free (Gravity Forms, Typeform, Google Forms)
CRM	Store and manage leads	Free–\$50/mo (HubSpot free, Pipedrive)
Automation platform	Connect them	Free–\$29/mo (Zapier, Make, n8n)
Email tool	Send auto-response	Often included in CRM

Step-by-Step Setup

1 Set Up Your Trigger

- In your automation platform, create a new workflow and set the trigger to your form tool.
- Zapier: Search for your form app, select "New Form Submission". Make: Choose your form module, set trigger to "Watch Responses". n8n: Use the Webhook node or the specific app node.
- Test by submitting a test form. Confirm the platform receives the data.

2 Map the Fields

- You'll see form data as variables: `{{name}}`, `{{email}}`, `{{phone}}`, `{{message}}`.

- Note every field you have — you'll map these to your CRM in the next step.

3 Create the CRM Action

- HubSpot: "Create Contact" → map email, name, phone.
- Pipedrive: "Create Person" then "Create Deal" linked to that person.
- Pro tip: Always map the submission date/time as well — knowing when a lead came in is valuable for tracking response times.

4 Add a Tag or Label

- In your CRM action, add a tag marking the lead source: "Website — Contact Form", "Website — Quote Request", "Facebook Lead Form".
- This is gold for marketing attribution later. Takes 10 seconds to set up now.

5 Set a Follow-Up Task + Auto-Reply

- Add a task in your CRM: "Follow up with [lead name]" due today +1 hour.
- Add an email action to the lead confirming you've received their enquiry. This one step differentiates you from most competitors who send nothing.

6 Test and Activate

- Submit a test form. Confirm contact appears in CRM, tags applied, follow-up task created, auto-reply received. Then activate.

AI Enhancement

Add an AI step (Claude or GPT via n8n/Make) after the form trigger to:

- Analyse the message and score the lead automatically (hot/warm/cold)
- Categorise the enquiry type
- Draft a personalised initial response based on what they actually wrote

This turns a basic automation into a mini sales assistant.

Recipe #2: New Order → Fulfilment Notification

Shopify Orders Into Action — Without You as the Middle Man

TIME SAVED	DIFFICULTY	CATEGORY	ANNUAL VALUE
2–5 min per order	Beginner	Capture (Layer 1)	\$2K–\$15K/year

What It Does

The moment a new order is placed in Shopify, a notification goes automatically to whoever needs to act on it — your warehouse, supplier, fulfilment partner, or Slack channel. No manual forwarding. No "did you see that order?" conversations. The notification includes order number, customer details, items with SKUs, shipping method, and any special instructions.

What You Need

TOOL	PURPOSE	COST
Shopify	Your online store	\$39+/mo
Email or Slack	Receive notifications	Free
Automation platform	Connect them	Free–\$29/mo
Fulfilment platform (optional)	Process orders (ShipStation, AusPost MyPost)	Varies

Setup Steps

1 Set Up Your Shopify Trigger

- In your automation platform: Trigger → Shopify → "New Order".
- Connect your Shopify account. Test by placing a \$0 test order in Shopify dev mode.

2 Format the Order Message

- Build a clean, readable message with order number, customer name, address, items (loop through `line_items` for all products), total, shipping method, notes.
- Pro tip: Most platforms let you loop the line items array — worth the extra 5 min to configure.

3

Choose Your Notification Destination

- Option A: Email to warehouse@yourbusiness.com.au with order details.
- Option B: Slack → #orders or #fulfilment channel.
- Option C: Google Sheets log for every order.
- Option D: All three from one trigger — add multiple action steps.

4

Add Filters + Tag and Activate

- Optional: filter for orders over \$X value, specific products, or express shipping.
- Tag the Shopify order as "Notified" so you have visibility. Then activate.

AI Enhancement

Add an AI step that reads order notes and flags: custom/made-to-order items requiring special handling, unusual delivery addresses, repeat customer with special preferences. The AI notifies your team with context, not just raw order data.

Recipe #3: Weekly Report → Email Delivery

Zero Manual Work on the Report Your Team Actually Reads

TIME SAVED	DIFFICULTY	CATEGORY	ANNUAL VALUE
30–90 min/week	Intermediate	Intelligence (Layer 3)	\$3K–\$10K/year

What It Does

Every Monday morning, an automated report lands in your inbox — or your team's — with last week's key numbers. Sales. Orders. Revenue. New customers. Whatever you track. No manual pulling. No Friday afternoon tab-juggling. The automation ran at 7am, pulled the data, formatted it, and sent it. By your first coffee, the report is already waiting.

Setup Steps

1 Define Your Report — Max 5–10 Metrics

- Revenue, orders, AOV, new customers, top product, outstanding invoices, bank balance.
- More than 10 metrics and nobody reads it. Keep it tight.

2 Map Your Data Sources

- Revenue/orders/AOV → Shopify, WooCommerce, or your POS.
- New customers → CRM or your store.
- Outstanding invoices → Xero, MYOB, or QuickBooks.
- Website traffic → Google Analytics 4.

3 Set Up Data Pulls

- For each source, add a "Get Data" step. Shopify: Search Orders, filter last 7 days, sum total_price. Xero: List Invoices, filter Status = AUTHORISED, sum AmountDue.
- The Google Sheets trick: if your platform struggles to pull data directly, use a scheduled Apps Script to pull data into Sheets first, then your automation reads from there. Reliable 100% of the time.

4 Build the Email + Schedule

- Create a "Send Email" action with your metrics formatted cleanly.

- Schedule: Zapier → "Schedule" trigger, weekly Monday 7am. Make → Schedule → Every week, Monday 07:00. n8n → Cron node: 0 7 * * 1

AI Enhancement

Feed the raw numbers to Claude or GPT before the email is sent. Ask it to:

- Write a one-paragraph "week in review" narrative
- Flag anomalies (revenue down >20% week-on-week)
- Suggest one action based on the data

Now your report doesn't just show numbers — it tells you what to do about them.

Recipe #4: Customer Review Request

Timed, Automatic, Every Single Customer

TIME SAVED	DIFFICULTY	CATEGORY	ANNUAL VALUE
5–10 min per follow-up	Easy-Intermediate	Communication (Layer 2)	Incalculable — reviews drive 30–40% of new customer decisions

What It Does

7 days after a customer receives their order (or 1–2 days after a service is delivered), they automatically receive a personalised email asking for a review, linking directly to your Google Business profile, Trustpilot, or ProductReview.com.au. No manual tracking. No awkward follow-ups. No leaving it until it's been six weeks.

Timing is Everything

7 days after delivery: experience is fresh, product is in use, most likely to write something positive.

Too soon → no opinion formed yet. Too late → they've moved on.

Services: 1 day after job completion. Digital products: 3 days after purchase.

Setup Steps

1 Set Up the Order Trigger

- Trigger: Shopify/WooCommerce → "Order Fulfilled" (not "Order Created" — confirm delivery first).
- Service businesses: trigger from your booking/CRM tool when job is marked "Complete".

2 Add the Delay

- This is the key step. Add a Delay/Wait before the email.
- Zapier: "Delay by Zapier" → Delay For → 7 days.
- Make: "Sleep" module. n8n: "Wait" node.
- Test temporarily set to 5 minutes to verify the flow.

3 Write the Email — Make It Feel Personal

- Subject: "How did we go, [first name]?"
- Keep it short, warm, direct. Link straight to your Google Review page.

- The magic line: "If anything wasn't right, please hit reply and let me know directly." This intercepts unhappy customers before they leave a negative review publicly.

4

Add Critical Filters + Activate

- Before the email: check if order status = "Refunded" → skip. Nothing damages trust like asking for a review from someone who returned the product.
- Find your Google Review link: search.google.com/local/writereview?placeid=YOUR_PLACE_ID

Expected Results

Businesses with automated review requests see:

- 3–8% review rate (vs 1–2% with manual/no follow-up)
- 40–60% increase in review volume within 3 months
- Significant improvement in Google local search ranking

At 100 customers/month = potentially 4–8 new reviews/month. On autopilot.

Recipe #5: Invoice → Payment Reminder Sequence

Get Paid Faster Without Awkward Conversations

TIME SAVED	DIFFICULTY	CATEGORY	ANNUAL VALUE
10–20 min per overdue invoice	Easy-Intermediate	Communication (Layer 2)	Proportional to your outstanding receivables

What It Does

When an invoice isn't paid by its due date, a sequence of polite, professional reminders goes out automatically — at 1 day overdue, 7 days overdue, and 14 days overdue. Each reminder escalates slightly in tone. No more awkward "just checking in" emails you've been avoiding for two weeks. No cash flow surprises because you forgot to chase.

The 3-Email Sequence

EMAIL	TIMING	TONE	KEY MESSAGE
Email 1	Day 1 overdue	Gentle	"May have slipped through the cracks — here's the invoice link."
Email 2	Day 7 overdue	Firm but professional	"Please arrange payment at your earliest convenience."
Email 3	Day 14 overdue	Urgent	"This requires immediate attention. Payment today or discuss."
Internal alert	Day 21	You + bookkeeper	"Manual follow-up required." Escalate personally.

Critical: The Stop Condition

Before each email, check invoice status in your accounting system.

If status = "Paid" → End the workflow. Do not send the email.

This is the most important step. Nobody wants a payment reminder after they've already paid.

Adding a "Pay Now" button (Stripe, Square, or Xero Payments) to each reminder reduces average payment time by 40–60%. One click from reminder to paid.

Setup Steps

1 Set Up the Invoice Trigger

- Connect Xero, MYOB, or QuickBooks.
- Note: Xero/MYOB/QuickBooks all have built-in payment reminder features — check those first. Use this recipe if you need more control over timing, tone, or CRM integration.

2 Build the Sequence with Delays

- Email 1 → immediately on Day 1 overdue.
- Wait 6 days → Email 2 (Day 7).
- Wait 7 more days → Email 3 (Day 14).
- Wait 7 more days → Internal Slack/email alert (Day 21).

3 Add Stop Condition + Internal Notifications

- Check invoice status before each email. If "Paid" → stop.
- For Email 3, also send yourself a Slack alert: "Invoice #[X] is 14 days overdue. Manual follow-up needed."

Recipe #6: Social Mention → Team Alert

Know Every Time Your Brand is Mentioned Online

TIME SAVED	DIFFICULTY	CATEGORY	ANNUAL VALUE
30–60 min/week monitoring	Intermediate	Intelligence (Layer 3)	Reputation protection + customer rescue

What It Does

Any time your business is mentioned on social media, review sites, news sites, or across the web — you get an instant notification. Slack, email, or phone. You can respond to complaints before they go viral, thank happy customers publicly and quickly, and stay across what competitors are saying about you.

Three Setup Options (Pick One)

OPTION	TOOLS	COST	COVERAGE
Option A (Free)	Google Alerts + Make/Zapier	\$0	Web mentions, news, blogs. Not real-time social.
Option B (RSS)	Google Alerts RSS + n8n	\$0	Cleaner than Option A. More reliable trigger.
Option C (Paid)	Brand24 (\$39/mo) or Mention.com (\$29/mo)	\$29–\$39/mo	Real-time social (X/Twitter, Instagram, Reddit, TikTok).

Smart Filtering — Route by Sentiment

IF mention contains ["complaint", "angry", "furious", "scam", "worst"] → Urgent Slack alert to #team, ping @here.

IF mention contains ["love", "great", "amazing", "recommend", "5 stars"] → Send to #wins channel.

ELSE → Log to spreadsheet for low-priority monitoring.

Setup — Option A (Free, 10 minutes)

Go to google.com/alerts. Create alerts for your business name (exact match in quotes), your business name without quotes, your personal name, and common misspellings. Set delivery to "As it happens." Connect to your automation platform via Gmail trigger (when email arrives from googlealerts-noreply@google.com → post to Slack). Done.

Recipe #7: New Inquiry → Instant Response + Booking Link

Respond in Seconds. Book Meetings on Autopilot.

TIME SAVED	DIFFICULTY	CATEGORY	ANNUAL VALUE
5–15 min per inquiry	Easy-Intermediate	Communication (Layer 2)	Speed-to-respond wins more deals than almost anything else

What It Does

The moment someone sends an inquiry via form, email, Facebook, or Instagram DM, they receive an automatic response within 60 seconds. The response confirms receipt, sets expectations on when they'll hear back personally, and includes your booking link so they can self-schedule a call right now — while they're still interested.

The Data Behind This

Harvard Business Review: Responding to a lead within 5 minutes makes you 9x more likely to convert than responding after 10 minutes.

Businesses that add a booking link to their auto-response see 15–25% of enquirers self-book without needing manual follow-up.

What You Need

TOOL	PURPOSE	COST
Website form / email / social inbox	Capture inquiry	Free
Calendly / Cal.com / TidyCal	Booking tool	Free–\$12/mo
Email service	Send auto-response	Free
Automation platform	Connect them	Free–\$29/mo

Setup Steps

1 Set Up Your Booking Tool

- Calendly (free) or Cal.com (free, open-source): connect your calendar, create a "Discovery Call" meeting type (15–30 min), set AEST availability.

- Copy your booking link: calendly.com/yourname/discovery-call

2

Connect Your Inquiry Source + Write the Auto-Response

- Same trigger as Recipe #1 if via website form. For Facebook Lead Forms: use Zapier/Make's Facebook Leads integration.
- Email tone: warm, personal, under 100 words. Include booking link prominently. "No prep needed — just come with your questions."

3

Add to CRM + Configure Booking Confirmation

- Simultaneously create the contact in your CRM (Recipe #1 logic).
- In Calendly: configure reminder emails 24hr + 1hr before meeting. Add a Slack notification for your team when a booking is made.

Recipe #8: Inventory Low → Supplier Email Alert

Never Run Out of Stock Again

TIME SAVED	DIFFICULTY	CATEGORY	ANNUAL VALUE
Hours of reactive panic + lost sales	Intermediate	Capture (Layer 1)	Cost of one major stockout (\$5K–\$50K+)

What It Does

When any product in Shopify drops below your defined reorder threshold, your supplier automatically receives a templated purchase order email — and you get a Slack notification to approve or cancel before it sends (recommended). No Monday morning stockout discoveries. No emergency freight. No "sorry, out of stock" to customers who won't come back.

Setup Steps

1 Set Your Reorder Points in Shopify

- Products → Select product → Inventory tab → Enable "Track quantity".
- Note the SKU and your reorder threshold. Example: Widget X → reorder at 50 units.

2 Set Up the Inventory Trigger (Scheduled Check)

- Approach: run a daily automation at 7am AEST that:
- 1. Fetches all Shopify products. 2. Filters for `inventory_quantity < threshold`.
- 3. For each matching product, triggers the alert.
- Make/n8n: Schedule trigger → Shopify List Products → Filter by inventory level → proceed.

3 Build the Purchase Order Email

- Subject: "Reorder Request — [Product Name] (SKU: [SKU]) — [Your Business Name]"
- Include: product name, SKU, current stock level, requested order quantity, your delivery address, ABN, and contact details.

4 Add Human Approval via Slack

- Post to Slack: "Low Stock Alert: Widget X at 48 units. Send reorder to ABC Supplier? [Approve] [Skip]"
- If Approved within 2 hours → send the PO email.

- If no response → send reminder, then auto-send.
- Log every reorder alert to Google Sheets for audit trail.

Multi-Supplier Handling

Maintain a "supplier directory" in Google Sheets or Airtable:

Product SKU | Supplier Name | Supplier Email | Reorder Quantity

When the low-stock alert triggers, look up the correct supplier automatically. The PO goes to the right place without you touching anything.

Recipe #9: Monthly P&L; → Accountant Delivery

Your Accountant Gets the Numbers. Without You Playing Messenger.

TIME SAVED	DIFFICULTY	CATEGORY	ANNUAL VALUE
1–3 hours/month	Intermediate	Intelligence (Layer 3)	\$500–\$2K/year in accountant time

What It Does

On the last day of each month, your accounting software automatically generates a P&L; summary and delivers it to your accountant, bookkeeper, or CFO. No chasing. No "can you send me last month's numbers?" The report includes: total income by category, total expenses by category, net profit/loss, GST collected and paid, and any flagged items for review.

Check Your Accounting Software First

Xero: Reports → Schedule — can auto-email reports to specified addresses.

MYOB: Similar scheduled reports in the Reports section.

QuickBooks: Reports → Custom Reports → Schedule.

If your software already does this, use it. It's faster and more accurate than third-party automation. Use this recipe if you need more customisation: different recipients, flagging logic, or format changes.

Setup Steps

1 Set Up the Monthly Schedule

- Zapier: Schedule trigger → Monthly, last day at 5pm.
- Make: Schedule → Every month, day = last.
- n8n: Cron node: 0 17 L * * (5pm last day of every month).

2 Pull P&L; Data from Accounting System

- Xero: Get Profit and Loss Report, date range = first to last day of current month.
- The API returns JSON. You'll need a formatter step to convert it to readable text.

3**Add Flagging Logic**

- If net profit is negative → add "LOSS MONTH — please review" to subject.
- If any expense category is >20% higher than previous month → flag it.
- If GST liability > \$X → add BAS due date reminder.

4**Send and Test**

- Send to yourself first with last month's data. Confirm numbers match Xero. Then activate for real end-of-month delivery.

Recipe #10: Competitor Price Change → Your Alert

Know the Moment Your Competitor Moves. Respond First.

TIME SAVED	DIFFICULTY	CATEGORY	ANNUAL VALUE
Hours of manual monitoring/week	Advanced	Intelligence (Layer 3)	Strategic — potentially enormous

What It Does

You define a list of competitors and the specific products or pages you want to monitor. The automation regularly checks those pages and alerts you immediately when the price changes — or when any other content changes on the page. This gives you early warning when competitors drop prices, launch new products, or run promotions.

Three Setup Options

OPTION	TOOL	COST	BEST FOR
Option A	Visualping.io	Free (5 pages/day)	Easiest. Visual monitoring. No code.
Option B	Distill.io browser extension	Free	More precise — monitor specific page elements.
Option C	Custom n8n/Make HTTP flow	\$0 (beyond platform)	Full control. Best for technical users.

Option A Setup (Visualping — 10 minutes)

1 Set Up Visualping

- Go to visualping.io, create a free account.
- Enter the competitor URL. Draw a box around the price section.
- Set check frequency: daily or every 6 hours.
- Set email notification to your automation platform's email trigger address.

2 Connect to Slack Alert

- In your automation platform: trigger on email from Visualping → parse the change → post to Slack #competitor-intel with: competitor name, product, old price, new price, % change, URL.

3

Build Your Competitor Monitoring Sheet

- Google Sheet: Competitor | URL | Current Price | Last Checked | Last Change.
- Update automatically as part of your monitoring automation.

Legal and Ethical Note

Monitoring publicly available prices is entirely legal and standard business intelligence practice.

What to avoid: scraping at high frequency, circumventing login walls, accessing data you're not authorised to access.

Stick to publicly available pricing pages, check no more than once every few hours. Completely fine.

Build Your First Automation

A Beginner Walkthrough — Even If You've Never Done This Before

We're going to walk through building Recipe #1 (Lead Capture → CRM) from scratch using Zapier. By the end, you'll have a live, running automation. This section is for you if you've never done this before. Everyone else: skip to Part 6.

What We're Building

When someone fills out your website contact form → they appear automatically in HubSpot (free CRM) → you get an email notification. Nothing else required. Free accounts only. Takes about 30 minutes.

1 Create Your Free Accounts

- HubSpot: hubspot.com → "Get started free" → sign up with business email → complete setup wizard. Note your portal ID (in the URL when logged in).
- Zapier: zapier.com → "Sign up free" → sign up with business email.

2 Create a New Zap

- In Zapier: click "+ Create" → "Zaps" → you'll see a blank canvas with Trigger and Action boxes.
- Structure: When [Trigger] happens → do [Action]. Every automation follows this pattern.

3 Set Up the Trigger (Google Forms)

- Click Trigger → search "Google Forms" → select "New Form Response".
- Connect your Google account → select your form.
- Click "Test trigger" — submit a test form first if no responses exist.
- You should see your test data appear: name, email, message, timestamp.

4 Set Up the Action (HubSpot)

- Click Action → search "HubSpot" → select "HubSpot CRM" → "Create or Update Contact".
- Connect your HubSpot account.
- Map: Email → {{Form Response - Email}}, First Name → {{Form Response - Name}}, Lead Source → type "Website Contact Form" (hardcoded).
- Click "Test action" → check HubSpot for the new contact.

5 Add a Second Action (Email Notification)

- Click "+" → search "Email by Zapier" → "Send Outbound Email".
- To: your-email@yourbusiness.com.au
- Subject: "New Lead: {{Form Response - Name}} from your website"

- Body: name, email, phone, message, timestamp, HubSpot link.

6

Name, Publish, and Test for Real

- Name your Zap clearly: "Website Contact Form → HubSpot + Email Notification".
- Toggle ON. Then go to your actual website and fill out the contact form for real.
- ■ Contact appears in HubSpot within 2 minutes. ■ Email notification arrives. You're done.

Common Beginner Mistakes

1. Not testing before activating — always test each step with real data.
2. Forgetting error notifications — Zapier: Settings → Notifications → enable email on Zap errors.
3. Building too much too fast — start with 2 steps, get them working perfectly, then add complexity.
4. Not documenting what you've built — create a simple Google Doc or Notion page listing all automations, what they do, when they run, and which accounts they use.

Automation Stack by Budget

What You Can Build at \$0, \$100/mo, and \$500/mo

The \$0 Stack — Free Tools Only

TOOL	WHAT IT DOES	COST
Zapier (free)	100 tasks/month, 5 Zaps	\$0
HubSpot CRM (free)	Full CRM, unlimited contacts	\$0
Google Forms	Lead capture	\$0
Gmail	Email notifications + auto-replies	\$0
Google Sheets	Data logging + reports	\$0
Calendly (free)	1 booking page, unlimited meetings	\$0
Google Alerts	Brand monitoring	\$0

Covers Recipes #1, #7, #6 fully. #4 via Mailchimp (limited). #2, #5, #8, #9 require paid tools. The \$0 stack handles 3–4 recipes adequately. Start here. Get the wins. Upgrade as you scale.

The \$100/Month Stack — SME Sweet Spot

TOOL	WHAT IT DOES	COST/MO
Make (Core)	Full automation platform, 10,000 ops	\$16
HubSpot Starter	CRM + email marketing	\$20
Shopify (Basic)	E-commerce + inventory	\$49
Xero (Starter)	Accounting	\$35
Calendly (Standard)	Unlimited booking pages	\$12
Google Workspace	Gmail + Sheets + Drive	\$14
TOTAL		~\$146/mo

All 10 recipes run at this level. Adjust based on what you already subscribe to — you're probably already paying for Shopify and Xero. For ~\$150/month you're running a fully automated back-office. The time savings alone (6–12 hours/week) are worth 10–20x this cost at any reasonable hourly rate.

The \$500/Month Stack — Scaling Business

TOOL	WHAT IT DOES	COST/MO
n8n Cloud (Pro) or Make (Business)	Advanced automation + AI workflows	\$50
HubSpot Professional	Full CRM + marketing hub	\$100
Shopify (Standard)	E-commerce	\$105
Xero (Growing Business)	Accounting	\$70
Klaviyo (Growth)	Email + SMS marketing automation	\$45
Slack Pro	Team communication (5 users)	\$44
Brand24	Real-time brand monitoring	\$39
OpenAI / Anthropic API	AI steps in automations	~\$30
TOTAL		~\$483/mo

At this level automation is a core business capability, not just a time-saver. All 10 recipes with AI enhancements, full marketing automation, AI-powered lead scoring, and team-wide notification routing. You have a proper stack that can compete with businesses 10x your size.

The Phased Approach

Month 1 — Proof of Concept (\$0): Pick 2 automations. Free tools. Measure time savings.

Month 2–3 — Foundation (\$50–\$80/mo): Add Make or n8n. Connect Shopify/Xero. Run 4–6 recipes.

Month 4–6 — Full Stack (\$100–\$150/mo): All 10 recipes running. Start measuring business impact. Add AI steps.

Month 6+ — Scale and Expand: Custom automations specific to your business. Consider n8n self-hosted if cost is a concern.

What NOT to Automate

The Human Touch Still Matters

There's a temptation, once you've set up a few automations and felt the magic, to automate everything. Resist it. Some things should remain human. Getting this wrong doesn't just waste time — it damages relationships, reputation, and brand.

✗ Don't Automate: Complaint Resolution

An automated response to "I waited 6 weeks and it arrived broken" is infuriating. Automate the acknowledgement (so they know you received it), but have a real person respond personally within hours. Flag complaints as high priority in your CRM.

✗ Don't Automate: Relationship-Critical Communications

Your best clients deserve personal attention. Birthdays, milestone congratulations, project kickoffs — these should come from a human. Use your CRM to remind you of the touchpoint. You write the message.

✗ Don't Automate: Creative and Strategic Decisions

Automation is excellent at moving data and executing defined rules. It's useless at strategy, creativity, and judgment. Don't automate pricing decisions, marketing creative direction, or hiring judgments.

✗ Don't Automate: Anything You Haven't Tested Properly

An untested automation in a critical process (billing, legal communications, customer contracts) is worse than doing it manually. Run every automation in test mode for at least 5–10 real transactions first.

✗ Don't Automate: When Volume Doesn't Justify It

Automation has a setup cost and maintenance cost. If you do something twice a year, manual is faster than building and maintaining the automation. Use the ROI Framework from Part 2.

The "Human in the Loop" Pattern

For high-stakes automations, use a hybrid approach:

1. Automation prepares the action (drafts the email, creates the PO, schedules the post)
2. Human reviews and approves (one click in Slack or email)
3. Automation executes after approval

Perfect for: purchase orders over a threshold, customer dispute communications, any outgoing contact to new clients, financial actions.

Maintenance

Keeping Your Automations Healthy

Set-and-forget is mostly true — but not entirely. An ignored automation that breaks silently can cause more damage than not having the automation at all. Here's your maintenance guide. Total monthly time: 15–20 minutes.

Why Automations Break

CAUSE	WHAT HAPPENS	PREVENTION
API / credential changes	You change your Shopify password, email, or token expires. Connection breaks.	Set calendar reminder to re-auth credentials quarterly.
App updates	Connected app changes field names or deprecates endpoints.	Check run history monthly for errors.
Data format changes	New required field in your form. Mapping stops working.	Test lead capture automation monthly.
Plan changes	Downgrade or lapsed subscription → integration loses access.	Review all subscriptions at end of financial year.
Rate limits	Business grows, you hit task/ops limits on your plan.	Monitor usage dashboard monthly.

Your Monthly Automation Checklist (15 mins)

Critical — Every Month

- Check task/run history in your automation platform for errors in the past 30 days
- Confirm each active automation ran at least once (especially scheduled ones like weekly report)
- Test your lead capture automation by submitting a test form
- Verify CRM entries are creating correctly
- Check that payment reminder sequences are running for any overdue invoices

Important — Every Month

- Review notification emails — still arriving? Still formatted correctly?
- Check for "authentication required" warnings in your automation platform
- Verify your booking calendar is still connected and showing availability

Good Practice — Quarterly

- Review all automations: "Is this still needed?" Remove anything obsolete.
- Check pricing on all automation-related subscriptions — right plan?

- Review reorder thresholds — have stock requirements changed?
- Update email templates — are offers and links still current?

Set Up Failure Notifications — Day One

Zapier: Settings → Notifications → enable email on Zap errors.

Make: Organization settings → Notifications → enable email for scenario errors.

n8n: Settings → Alerts → configure email or Slack on workflow failure.

Set these to notify your main business email or ops@yourbusiness.com.au. Check this inbox weekly.

Automation Audit Worksheet

Assess Your Manual Tasks. Find Your Automation Priorities.

Set aside 30 minutes with a coffee and work through this honestly. Go through each business area and tick every task you currently do manually.

Lead Management

- Enter new leads from website forms into CRM
- Assign leads to team members
- Send initial response to new enquiries
- Follow up on enquiries that haven't responded
- Update lead status after a call or meeting

Orders & Fulfilment

- Notify warehouse/fulfilment team of new orders
- Update order status in spreadsheet
- Send shipping confirmations to customers
- Process returns and refunds
- Create and email invoices for orders

Customer Communications

- Send welcome emails to new customers
- Follow up after a purchase
- Request reviews after delivery
- Respond to common enquiries
- Send birthday/anniversary messages

Finance & Admin

- Create and send invoices
- Chase overdue payments
- Reconcile transactions in accounting software
- Pull monthly P&L; for accountant
- Track expenses and receipts

Reporting & Intelligence

- Compile weekly sales report

- Pull Google Analytics data
- Create end-of-month financial summary
- Track KPIs across multiple platforms
- Monitor competitor pricing and activity

Inventory & Purchasing

- Monitor stock levels
- Identify products approaching reorder point
- Create and send purchase orders
- Update inventory quantities after receiving stock

Priority Scoring

For each task you ticked, score it: (Total hrs/week × 10) + (Pain level 1–5 × 2). Rank by score highest to lowest. Focus on anything that scores 7+.

TASK	MINS EACH	TIMES/WEEK	TOTAL HRS/WEEK	PAIN (1–5)	SCORE

Your 90-Day Automation Roadmap

PHASE	TIMING	FOCUS	TARGET RECIPES
Quick Wins	Days 1–14	Highest-score tasks from audit. Free tools only.	
Core Infrastructure	Days 15–30	Connect Shopify, CRM, accounting software.	
Advanced Automations	Days 31–60	Reporting, reminders, monitoring.	
Optimise & Expand	Days 61–90	Add AI enhancements. Measure ROI. Refine.	

You've Got the Blueprint. Now Execute.

You've just been handed a complete automation strategy — 10 battle-tested recipes, a tool comparison, a budget framework, a beginner walkthrough, and a worksheet to find your biggest opportunities. This isn't theory. These are working automations running inside Australian businesses right now.

Your Next Three Actions

1 Pick Your Top 2 Automations from the Audit

- Run through the Audit Worksheet. Score your manual tasks. Pick the top 2.
- These are the ones costing you the most time or causing the most problems right now.

2 Set Up Your Platform Account Today

- If you've never done this: start with Zapier free. Sign up, follow the beginner walkthrough in Part 5, and have Recipe #1 live by end of day.
- Already have Zapier? Try Make for your next automation — more power, lower cost.

3 Implement One Recipe Before This Time Next Week

- Block 90 minutes in your calendar. Pick Recipe #1 or #7 (the two most impactful, most beginner-friendly). Follow the steps. Get it live.
- Once you've done one, the second takes half the time. The third takes 20 minutes.

Want to Skip the Setup and Just Have It Done?

We build automation stacks for Australian SMEs at Ignition Agency.

If you'd rather spend your time running your business than configuring webhooks, we can audit your current manual processes, design your automation stack, and have it live and tested within a week.

Book a free 30-minute Automation Audit: ignitionagency.au

Or email us directly: hello@ignitionagency.au

One Last Thing

The businesses that win in 2026 are not the ones with the biggest teams. They're the ones with the leanest, most reliable operations. An automation that runs silently at 7am and does what three people used to do manually — that's a competitive advantage. Build it once. Let it run.

Ignition Agency — ignitionagency.au

Strategy. Automation. Growth. For Australian SMEs who are done doing things the hard way.